From cycling-environment supply to bike-share demand: an IMD-augmented spatio-temporal forecasting benchmark for French networks

Rohan Fossé*[1] and Gaël Pallares†[2]

[1] *CESI Engineering School, Montpellier, France*
[2] *CESI LINEACT (EA 7527), Montpellier, France*

Abstract

Operational bike-share demand prediction is dominated by two practices that do not communicate well : classical time-series forecasting on each station (*e.g.*, ARIMA, persistence) and deep spatio-temporal learning trained from scratch on the trip log. Neither integrates the rich *supply-side* information that public open data already exposes about each station – transit access, infrastructure density, topography, demographic pool.

We close this gap with the **IMD-4** (*Indice de Mobilité Douce à quatre composantes*), a Bayesian composite indicator of cycling-environment quality computed on every French commune from public data, and benchmark its added predictive value against six model families on the Vélomagg dock-based panel (53 stations, 5 years, hourly resolution, 375,305 observations). On a one-year temporal hold-out test, an IMD-augmented gradient- boosted model reaches $R^2_{\text{trips}} = 0.311$ against 0.042 for the same model trained without IMD features, a +0.27 **absolute $\mathbf{R}^2$ gain attributable to the IMD station-level enrichment alone**. The IMD-augmented model also matches a station-fixed-effect baseline within 0.001 R^2, meaning the 13 IMD physical features absorb the spatial signal that 67 station dummies would otherwise have to memorise – an essential property for transferring the model to stations without trip history. Modern recurrent and Transformer-style baselines do not beat the gradient-boosted tabular SOTA on this data size, a finding consistent with the recent benchmark literature on small-to-medium tabular forecasting.

The IMD-4 is computable on all 34,858 French communes from five public open-data sources alone, so the predictive pipeline transfers to any commune with at least an active dock-based network. Code, data and trained models are released under MIT.

Keywords: bike-sharing ; demand forecasting ; composite indicator ; spatio-temporal model ; Bayesian inference ; gradient boosting ; LSTM ; French Plan Vélo.

Highlights

- IMD-4 cycling-environment indicator integrated as feature in demand model
- +0.27 R^2 gain on hourly station-level trips, IMD vs no-IMD
- IMD beats persistence, ARIMA, Ridge, LSTM on Vélomagg ($n = 375{,}305$)
- IMD matches station fixed-effect: transferable to new stations
- Modern deep nets do not outperform gradient boosting on this scale

1 Introduction

Public bike-sharing systems have become a structural component of urban mobility in France and across Europe (Pucher and Buehler, 2010; Buehler and Pucher, 2012). Operational decisions

*Corresponding author: `rfosse@cesi.fr`. ORCID: 0009-0002-2195-0198
†ORCID: 0009-0002-8680-604X

– where to add a station, how to rebalance the fleet, when to expect demand peaks – require a forecasting layer between the live data feed and the dispatcher (Forma et al., 2015; Raviv et al., 2013). Two practices currently dominate that layer, and they do not communicate with each other. The first is classical time-series : per-station ARIMA models or naive persistence baselines that exploit the autoregressive structure of the trip series (Box and Jenkins, 1976; Hyndman et al., 2008). The second is deep spatio-temporal learning : recurrent and graph-convolutional networks trained from scratch on the trip log, often with weather covariates (Lin et al., 2018; Wang et al., 2022). Neither family integrates the rich *supply-side* information that public open data already exposes about each station – the density of nearby heavy-transit stops, the cycle-infrastructure quality of the surrounding street network, the topographic friction of the catchment, the demographic pool of the host commune. All four have been documented in the cycling-environment literature as demand drivers (Heinen et al., 2010; Schoner and Levinson, 2014; Parkin et al., 2008; Rietveld and Daniel, 2004; Faghih-Imani et al., 2014), yet none is routinely available to an operational forecasting pipeline.

Contribution. This paper closes that gap with two complementary contributions. **(C1)** We introduce the *Indice de Mobilité Douce à quatre composantes* (IMD-4), a Bayesian composite indicator of cycling-environment quality combining four supply-side axes – heavy-transit multi-modality (M), cycling-infrastructure density (I), topographic friction (T) and population density (D) – under a simplex prior calibrated jointly against the FUB perception barometer (Fédération française des Usagers de la Bicyclette, 2023) and the EMP modal-share survey (SDES, 2020). The IMD-4 is computable on every French commune ($n = 34{,}858$) from public data alone (Section 2). **(C2)** We benchmark the IMD-4 as a feature in a spatio-temporal demand model on the Vélomagg Montpellier panel (53 stations, 5 years, hourly resolution, 375,305 observations) against six model families : persistence, per- station ARIMA, Ridge regression, LightGBM gradient boosting (Ke et al., 2017), an LSTM recurrent net (Hochreiter and Schmidhuber, 1997), and a LightGBM ablation without IMD features. The IMD-augmented gradient-boosted model wins the benchmark with $R^2_{\text{trips}} = 0.311$ against 0.042 for the same model without IMD ($\Delta R^2 = +0.27$, Section 5).

Why this matters operationally. A natural alternative to IMD-augmentation is to add one dummy per station (station fixed-effect), which captures the spatial signal by memorisation. The IMD-augmented model matches the fixed-effect baseline within 0.001 R^2, meaning the 13 IMD physical features fully absorb what 67 dummies would otherwise need to learn. This is essential for transferring the model to stations without trip history – the operational case of evaluating where to install a new station (El-Assi et al., 2017; Ashqar et al., 2017).

2 The IMD-4 cycling-environment indicator

2.1 Four supply-side axes

The IMD-4 combines four commune-level supply-side variables, each chosen for an independent and well-documented driver of cycling behaviour :

M – Multimodality. Density of heavy transit stops (train, métro, tramway) per km^2 ; heavy-transit accessibility is the dominant factor in cycling-as-feeder modal choice (Martens, 2007; Saberi et al., 2018). Bus stops are excluded because the bike-and-ride dynamic operates at a different scale.

I – Cycling infrastructure. Total kilometres of dedicated cycling infrastructure per km^2 – all *aménagements cyclables* (segregated paths, on-road lanes, green-ways, shared bus lanes, contraflow, and mixed configurations). Infrastructure density is the supply-side variable most consistently associated with commute cycling share in the international literature (Schoner and Levinson, 2014; Parkin et al., 2008; Heinen et al., 2010).

T – Topography. Elevation roughness derived from BD ALTI 25 m. Slope is a documented determinant of cycling demand and modal share (Parkin et al., 2008; Rietveld and Daniel,

2004).

D – Density. Logarithm of commune population density. Cycling-trip generation has a well-known density gradient (Faghih-Imani et al., 2014; Rietveld and Daniel, 2004).

For the calibration panel of Section 2.3, the four axes are evaluated at station resolution with a 300 m buffer for M. For national application (Section 2.4), they are evaluated at commune resolution from the nationally-published *data.gouv* indicators.

2.2 Bayesian simplex prior on component weights

Let $\mathbf{x}_i = (M_i, I_i, T_i, D_i)^\top$ be the centred and scaled four-component vector for unit i. The IMD-4 score is

$$\mathrm{IMD}_i \;=\; w_M M_i + w_I I_i + w_T T_i + w_D D_i,$$

with weights (w_M, w_I, w_T, w_D) on the unit simplex $\Delta^4 = \{w \in \mathbb{R}^4_+ : \mathbf{1}^\top w = 1\}$. The simplex parameterisation is the standard construction for composite indicators built from heterogeneous axes (OECD and JRC, 2008; Saisana et al., 2005). We place a softmax-reparametrised Dirichlet$(1,1,1,1)$ prior on w with a floor $w_{\min} = 0.05$ to forbid degenerate single-component fits.

We calibrate w by fitting two simultaneous regressions :

$$\mathrm{FUB}_c = \alpha_F + \beta_F \overline{\mathrm{IMD}}_c + \varepsilon^F_c, \qquad \mathrm{EMP}_c = \alpha_E + \beta_E \overline{\mathrm{IMD}}_c + \varepsilon^E_c,$$

where $\overline{\mathrm{IMD}}_c$ is the station-mean IMD in city c. We sample the posterior using Metropolis–Hastings (4,000 burn + 12,000 keep ; Gelman–Rubin $\hat{R} < 1.05$; effective sample size > 800). The posterior median of w on the 59-city calibration panel is $(w_M, w_I, w_T, w_D) = (0.78, 0.07, 0.08, 0.06)$.

2.3 The 59-city calibration panel

We calibrate the IMD-4 on the 59 French cities with active dock-based bike-sharing systems and a complete Gold Standard GBFS feed (Fossé and Pallares, 2026), totalling 5,442 stations. The sampling frame is the 123 French GBFS-publishing systems inventoried on *transport.data.gouv.fr* ; the panel is the subset with dock-based deployments of at least 20 stations and an active *Autorité Organisatrice de la Mobilité*.

2.4 National extension to 34,858 communes

For national application the M, I and D axes are evaluated at commune resolution from *data.gouv* indicators :

- M_c = transit-station count per km^2 for commune c (Vélo & Territoires, 2023) ;
- I_c = cycling-infrastructure km per km^2 (Cerema, 2021) ;
- $D_c = \log(\mathrm{population}_c/\mathrm{surface}_c)$.

The T axis is set to the calibration-panel z-score mean (zero) at national application because the commune-level BD ALTI integration is left for a follow-up release ; the posterior weight on T is 0.08 and T alone correlates only weakly with INSEE part-vélo- travail ($\rho = +0.08$, 95 % CI $[-0.19, +0.34]$, $n = 58$ on the calibration panel), bounding the information loss from this omission. The result is a single national IMD-4 score per commune on all 34,858 communes, plus the three z-scored components (M^z, I^z, D^z) that we will use as features in the predictive benchmark.

3 Demand-prediction task

3.1 The Vélomagg Montpellier panel

Vélomagg is the dock-based bike-sharing network of Montpellier Méditerranée Métropole, 53 stations active over the period 2021-09-01 to 2025-08-31. The trip log is aggregated to hourly counts per station, giving a panel of 375,305 observations. Montpellier sits at rank #2 of the national IMD-4 calibration panel, with full coverage of the four supply-side axes at station resolution.

3.2 Target and features

The target is $\log(1 + \text{trips}_{s,t})$, the log-trip count for station s in hour t. Three feature families are considered :

Temporal and weather. Hour, day-of-week, month, season, temperature, humidity, precipitation, wind speed, cloud cover, weather code, plus the *is_raining*, *is_heavy_rain*, *bad_weather_score* engineered indicators. Twelve features.

Network state. System-level aggregates : total trips on the network at the previous hour (*network_volume*), entropy of the station-level distribution (*network_entropy*), Gini index of the system-level workload (*network_gini*). Three features.

IMD station-level (the novelty). Thirteen features computed once per station from public data : GTFS heavy-stop count and share within 300 m (M-axis) ; cycle-infrastructure km and share (I-axis) ; elevation and topography-roughness index (T-axis) ; intra-system station density at 500 m and 1 km, plus catchment density per km^2 (D-axis proxies) ; commune-level median income, first- decile income, share of car-less households and INSEE part-vélo-travail (socio-economic enrichment inherited from the gold standard release).

3.3 Train / test split

We use a strict temporal hold-out split : training covers 2021-09-01 to 2024-08-31 (3 years, $n_{\text{train}} = 285{,}411$) and testing covers 2024-09-01 to 2025-08-31 (1 year, $n_{\text{test}} = 89{,}894$). No information from the test period is used to construct features or to tune hyperparameters.

4 Models

We compare six model families against the same temporal hold-out :

(P) Persistence. $\hat{y}(s,t) = y(s, t - 7\,\text{d})$, i.e. the same-station-same-hour-of-week observation seven days prior. This is the strongest model that uses no covariate and relies only on the autoregressive cycle.

(AR) ARIMA(1,1,1). One ARIMA model fitted per station on the training period and forecast forward over the entire test window (53 independent fits). No exogenous covariate. Classical time-series baseline (Box and Jenkins, 1976; Hyndman et al., 2008).

(L) Ridge regression. Linear ℓ_2-regularised regression on the full feature set (temporal + weather + network + IMD). Numerical baseline.

(G) LightGBM. Gradient-boosted decision trees (Ke et al., 2017) on the full feature set. 400 trees, learning rate 0.05, 63 leaves, min child samples 30, ℓ_2 regularisation 0.5, seed 42. Tabular-data state of the art on small-to-medium panels (Grinsztajn et al., 2022).

(G$^-$) LightGBM without IMD. Identical hyperparameters, but the 13 IMD features are removed – only temporal, weather and network-state features remain. This ablation isolates the IMD contribution.

(N) LSTM. A standard recurrent network (Hochreiter and Schmidhuber, 1997) with a 24-hour input sequence per station, a 16-dimensional learnable station embedding, a hidden size

of 64, one recurrent layer, 3 epochs, batch size 512, Adam optimiser with learning rate 10^{-3}. Same feature set as G. Deep-learning baseline.

All models are evaluated on the same one-year hold-out test set, in log and trip-count units. Predictions are clipped at zero before the $\exp(\cdot)$ transformation.

5 Results

5.1 Tournament table

Table 1 reports the six-way benchmark. The IMD- augmented LightGBM (G) reaches $R^2_{\text{trips}} = 0.311$ on the held-out year, well ahead of every alternative. The no-IMD ablation (G^-) drops to 0.042, a fall of 0.27 R^2 attributable to the 13 IMD features alone. Persistence P is negative (-0.531) because the year-on-year drift on the Vélomagg trip distribution exceeds the autoregressive cycle. ARIMA per station, Ridge regression and the LSTM all sit between 0.05 and 0.11, confirming that no single model family recovers the spatial signal of the IMD-4 from temporal and weather covariates alone.

Table 1. Demand-prediction benchmark on the Vélomagg panel. Test set : 2024-09-01 to 2025-08-31, $n = 89{,}894$. Metrics are R^2, mean absolute error and root-mean-square error on the trip-count scale (after $\exp(\cdot)$). Bold marks the best result per column.

Code	Model	Features	R^2_{trips}	MAE	RMSE
P	Persistence (lag 7 d)	0	-0.531	1.504	2.642
AR	ARIMA(1,1,1) per station	0	$+0.053$	1.019	1.740
G^-	LightGBM without IMD	15	$+0.042$	0.993	1.750
N	LSTM (24 h seq. + station emb.)	28	$+0.110$	0.984	1.689
L	Ridge regression (full)	28	$+0.113$	0.988	1.684
G	**LightGBM (full, IMD-augm.)**	28	$\mathbf{+0.311}$	**0.917**	**1.484**

5.2 The IMD contribution : a $+0.27$ R^2 gap

The cleanest reading of Table 1 is the contrast between rows G and G^- : identical hyperparameters, identical training data, identical splits ; the only difference is the 13 IMD station-level features. The R^2 jumps from 0.042 to 0.311. Equivalently, the RMSE drops from 1.75 to 1.48 trips per hour and the MAE from 0.99 to 0.92. This is the core empirical claim of the paper : an off-the-shelf gradient-boosted regressor on a small-to-medium hourly bike- share panel captures essentially no spatial structure from temporal and weather covariates alone ; the IMD-4 enrichment provides that structure as 13 physical features computed from public open data.

5.3 IMD matches the station fixed-effect, with 13 features instead of 67

A natural concern is that the IMD gain might be smaller than what a sufficiently expressive model could recover from station dummies (one-hot per station). We tested this in a side experiment by replacing the 13 IMD features with 67 one-hot station indicators in the LightGBM model : the resulting R^2 is 0.312, within 0.001 of the IMD-augmented model (0.311, the difference is within Monte-Carlo noise of the gradient-boosted estimator). Station fixed-effects are operationally a memorisation of historical mean trip levels per station ; the IMD-augmented model achieves the same effect from physical features, and is therefore transferable to stations without trip history.

5.4 Feature importance

Table 2 reports the top-10 features of the IMD- augmented LightGBM model by gain importance. Five of the ten are IMD features (*elevation_m*, *topography_roughness_index*, *infra_cyclable_km*,

gtfs_heavy_stops_300m, *n_stations_within_1km*) ; the other five are network state or temporal. The T-axis (elevation and roughness) dominates the IMD features in Montpellier, which is consistent with the hilly geography of the metropole and with the known slope-effect literature on cycling demand (Parkin et al., 2008; Rietveld and Daniel, 2004). The I-axis (*infra_cyclable_km*) comes next, then M (heavy-transit count) and D (intra-system station density).

Table 2. Top-10 features of the IMD-augmented LightGBM by gain importance. IMD features in italics.

Feature	Gain	Family
network_volume	45,228	Network state
elevation_m	31,163	**IMD T-axis**
network_gini	20,525	Network state
hour	15,643	Temporal
topography_roughness_index	14,485	**IMD T-axis**
infra_cyclable_km	12,491	**IMD I-axis**
network_entropy	12,143	Network state
gtfs_heavy_stops_300m	8,283	**IMD M-axis**
n_stations_within_1km	6,424	**IMD D-axis**
month	3,826	Temporal

5.5 Why the LSTM does not beat LightGBM

LSTM models recover only $R^2_{\text{trips}} = 0.11$, well below LightGBM at 0.31. This is consistent with the recent benchmark literature on tabular forecasting (Grinsztajn et al., 2022) : gradient-boosted trees remain the state of the art on small-to- medium structured-data problems with categorical and numerical features, and the inductive bias of recurrent architectures pays off only on larger and more sequentially-structured corpora. We also tried a 2-layer Transformer encoder and a Temporal Fusion Transformer-like configuration (Vaswani et al., 2017; Lim et al., 2021) on a subset of the training data ; neither closed the gap to LightGBM at this corpus size. Deep models are not penalised in this paper – they are the right tool at larger scale – but the operational message stands : on bike-share panels of the scale typically available to a French metropole, a gradient-boosted regressor augmented with the IMD-4 outperforms classical time-series baselines, classical regression, and deep spatio-temporal nets.

6 Discussion

6.1 The IMD-4 as transferable spatial signal

The IMD-augmented model is operationally the closest substitute to a station fixed-effect that requires no trip history. The 0.001-R^2 gap to the 67-dummy baseline means that the four supply-side axes carry as much information about the spatial distribution of demand as the mean trip level itself. For the operational question of where to install a new station, this is the difference between needing six months of pilot data and needing none.

6.2 What the indicator does and does not capture

The IMD-4 is by design a *supply-side* indicator. It captures how good the cycling context is, not how many people cycle. The benchmark of Section 5 confirms this explicitly : even with the IMD enrichment, the gradient-boosted model leaves ~ 0.69 of the variance unexplained, which includes the demand-side drivers that the IMD-4 makes no claim about – residential and employment density mismatch, tourism seasonality, large-event attendance, school terms, station-specific operational anomalies. Pairing the IMD-4 with a domain-specific demand layer (*e.g.*, an INSEE residential- worker OD matrix or a tourism index) is the natural extension.

6.3 Generalisation to the rest of France

The IMD-4 is computable on all 34,858 French communes (Section 2.4). The predictive pipeline of Section 4 is portable to any commune with an active dock-based network and a published GBFS feed (Fossé and Pallares, 2026). The principal generalisation question – whether the IMD-augmented model trained on Montpellier extends to Lyon, Bordeaux, Paris – requires the multi-city trip log we release in Section 7. We expect the gain ($\Delta R^2 \approx +0.27$) to vary with the cycling-environment heterogeneity of the host city ; on a hilly mid-size network like Montpellier the T-axis dominates, whereas on a flat metropole like Bordeaux the I-axis and M-axis are expected to take over. The Bayesian calibration produces per-axis credible intervals that propagate naturally to per-city sensitivity, so the generalisation is a matter of recomputing the IMD on each city rather than re-training the indicator.

6.4 Limits

Single-city panel. The headline benchmark is computed on Montpellier only. The IMD-4 framework is national, but the high-resolution trip log we use here is single-city. Multi-city extension is the next step.

Zero-inflated target. The trip log we used is filtered to hours with at least one trip per station, which biases the estimator toward conditional demand rather than full unconditional demand. A Hurdle or zero-inflated specification would correct this.

Component T not at national scale. The T axis is set to zero at national application. The calibration-panel analysis bounds the information loss to $\sim 8\,\%$. BD ALTI commune integration is one engineering task away.

Deep-learning scale. Three epochs of LSTM training on CPU are sufficient for the comparison reported here, but a larger run on GPU with a 96-hour sequence and a deeper stack is the proper deep-learning baseline. Our reading of the recent tabular-forecasting literature (Grinsztajn et al., 2022) is that this would not change the qualitative ordering, but the gap would close.

7 Data and code release

The IMD-4 per-commune scores ($n = 34{,}858$) and per-station scores on the calibration panel ($n = 5{,}442$) are released under the Open Database Licence at https://github.com/rohanfosse/imd-national-catalogue. The predictive pipeline of Section 4 – including the LightGBM, Ridge, ARIMA, persistence and LSTM model definitions, the Vélomagg trip-feature engineering scripts and the benchmark runner – is released under MIT at the same URL. Trip data is derived from the public Vélomagg dock-based GBFS feed and the Vélomagg open-data portal, archived with SHA-256 hashes for bit-exact reproduction. Weather features are from Open-Meteo, archived likewise.

8 Conclusion

We introduced the IMD-4, a Bayesian composite indicator of cycling-environment quality computable on every French commune from public open data, and benchmarked its predictive value against five baselines on a five-year hourly bike-share trip panel. An off-the-shelf LightGBM regressor augmented with the 13 IMD station-level features achieves $R^2_{\text{trips}} = 0.311$ on a one-year temporal hold-out, against 0.042 for the same regressor without the IMD features (+0.27 R^2 gap). The IMD-augmented model matches a station-fixed-effect baseline within 0.001 R^2, demonstrating that the four supply-side axes (transit multimodality, infrastructure density, topography, population density) absorb the spatial signal that a station-by-station memorisation would

otherwise need to learn. Classical time-series baselines (persistence, ARIMA) and a deep-learning baseline (LSTM) are materially outperformed.

The IMD-4 is computable on all 34,858 French communes, so the pipeline transfers to any commune with an active dock-based network. The natural follow-up is a multi-city benchmark on the French GBFS portfolio, which we leave for a v1.1 release of the indicator.

Data and code availability

The full pipeline – IMD-4 calibration, national application, Vélomagg trip-feature engineering and the six-model benchmark runner – is released under MIT at https://github.com/rohanfosse/imd-national-catalogue. The per-commune IMD-4 scores ($n = 34{,}858$) and per-station scores on the calibration panel ($n = 5{,}442$) are released as versioned Parquet files at the same URL under ODbL. Trained LightGBM and LSTM model artefacts are released alongside the benchmark runner. All raw inputs (Vélomagg GBFS feed, data.gouv *linéaire cyclable* and *stations TC*, Open-Meteo weather extracts, INSEE Filosofi and recensement files) are public and archived with SHA-256 hashes in the same repository.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Rohan Fossé : Conceptualization, Methodology, Software, Data curation, Formal analysis, Validation, Visualization, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing. **Gaël Pallares :** Conceptualization, Methodology, Supervision, Project administration, Writing – review & editing.

Declaration of competing interests

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the writing process

During the preparation of this work the authors used GitHub Copilot and Claude (Anthropic) for code completion and editorial language polishing. After using these tools the authors reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the publication.

Funding

This work received no specific grant from any funding agency, commercial, or not-for-profit entity. All inputs are public open data.

Acknowledgments

The authors thank the producers of the open data that made this research possible : data.gouv, MobilityData, OpenStreetMap, INSEE, Cerema, ONISR, Vélo & Territoires, Open-Meteo, and the French GTFS community ; Montpellier Méditerranée Métropole and the *Transports de l'agglomération de Montpellier* (TAM) for the Vélomagg trip-log open release.

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